

The Clay Man

In the beginning, the gods formed Kamile from the best earth and a single, merciless idea. They gave him hands that understood clay as unerringly as a mother understands a child's cry. He could see a human shape hidden inside a formless block and was compelled to find it. Then they stepped back—as gods do—and watched what he would make of their gift. Kamile lived alone on the edge of a nameless village, in a red-soiled valley between two hills that people said belonged to Hephaestus.

The god never confirmed this. The soil there was heavy and rich—good for vessels, roof tiles and, if one knew how, for men. Kamile knew how. His workshop was a single room: a dirt floor, a high window that caught the morning light at just the right angle, tools hanging neatly on the walls and buckets of water drawn fresh from the stream each day. The air always smelled of deep earth—of something buried just below the surface.

After a lifetime of breathing it, Kamile thought of it simply as the smell of being alive. He was neither young nor old. He was at that indefinable age when a man stops counting years and simply continues. In the centre of his workshop stood a long table. On it rested his current work: a man—nearly. The proportions were right. He had learned balance the hard way, through failures he refused to forget. The chest was broad enough to bear grief.

The hands were open because a man should not enter the world as a fist. He always made the face last. The face was where the soul entered, and that moment never failed to unsettle him. He did it anyway. Kamile sat on his low stool and studied the clay man. Outside, goats grazed the hillside. A woman shouted at someone in a language of pure irritation. Sunlight came through the high window and lay across the table and the unfinished chest, illuminating the dust motes.

Kamile considered what he was about to do. He knew his purpose. The gods had not hidden it. His mother's choice of name—Kamile, "one who sacrifices"—had been guided by something she did not understand. He had learned its meaning in a city's library when he was young, in a book that smelled of dried ink and certainty. One given to sacred rites of loss. His mother had thought it beautiful. He pressed his thumb into the centre of the clay man's chest. What flowed into the clay was not exactly pain.

It was like the feeling when a word you have always known suddenly becomes strange in your mouth: a loosening, a faint wrongness, a tiny piece of the world shifting. Something essential in him moved silently, without ceremony, as heat moves from a warm hand to cold stone. He felt it leave. He always did. Then the clay man breathed. It was not dramatic. The still chest moved cautiously, as though testing the strength of a floor. It rose again, then found a steady rhythm.

Kamile sat back and watched the blank face turn slowly toward him. Even without features, it was already questioning, already someone. He would craft the face tomorrow. Tonight, he would let the new being breathe and learn the room. Kamile wiped his hands on the cloth at his belt. He looked at what he had made and felt, as he always felt at that moment, a joy the gods had planted in him like a knife in fruit: clean, deep and entirely his, whatever their intentions.

He did not look away from it and did not apologise for it. Outside, the goats moved on, the woman still called, and the light in the high window reddened like embers. In the workshop that smelled of earth, two beings sat breathing in the near-dark: one made that morning and one who, with each making, gave up a little more of himself.

Chapter One — Primo

Kamile finished the clay man's face on the third morning. He worked slowly with his smallest tools, which he kept wrapped in oilcloth. He gave him a broad nose, a low brow and a mouth that settled into a natural, almost-smile—one that made strangers feel they were already known. He made the ears stick out slightly; perfection unnerved him, and he'd never trusted a man with perfect ears. When he was finished, he sat back and looked. *You, he thought. Let's see what you do with it.* He did not name him yet. He never named them until they had been awake long enough to deserve it.

The soul was present, but a man is completed in his first hours of moving through a world that resists him. Kamile had learned to wait. On the third morning, the clay man—who would later be called Primo—sat up like someone who has slept longer than intended. He examined his hands, turning them over, pressing fingertip to fingertip and noting the resistance with satisfaction—or at least without alarm. Then he looked at Kamile with the eyes Kamile had given him—dark, deep-set and patient. He said nothing because he had no language yet, only a dawning awareness of being. For a first morning, that is enough.

FINGERPRINTS: KAMILE

Right Thumb

Recovered from clay chest cavity.

WITNESS NOTE
(HEARD OUTSIDE)

- ☒ Goats grazing
- ☒ Woman shouting (angrily)
- ☒ Morning light through window

Recorded by:
M. Theros

FIELD OBSERVER'S SKETCH



WITNESS STATEMENTS — FORM 17B

NAME / ROLE	STATEMENT (SUMMARY)	SIGNATURE
MAGISTRATE DORION (Civic Authority)	Observed event at dawn. Clay figure exhibited respiration without external aid.	<i>[Signature]</i>
PHILOSOPHER LYKEON (Natural Inquiries)	Subject demonstrates emergent properties warranting inquiry.	<i>[Signature]</i>
LAB SUPERVISOR HERAION (Research Council)	Recommend continued monitoring and ethical review.	<i>[Signature]</i>

FILED: DAY 1

FOR OFFICIAL USE ONLY

IDENTITY TAG

SUBJECT: CLAY MAN
STATUS: UNNAMED
ORIGIN: KAMILE'S WORKSHOP
LOCATION: RED-SOILED VALLEY
CLASSIFICATION: UNDETERMINED
OBSERVATION: ACTIVE
DATE: DAWN, DAY 1



MAGISTRATE DORION
CIVIC AUTHORITY

Keep under review.
If it breathes, it may
be subject to law.

PHILOSOPHER LYKEON
NATURAL INQUIRIES

What is it when
something is made
and yet begins
on its own?

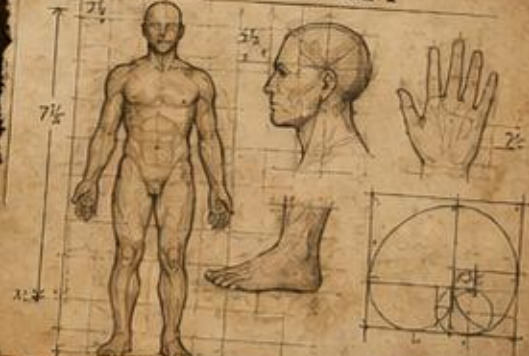


LAB SUPERVISOR HERAION
RESEARCH COUNCIL

Recommend observation
protocols. Handle with
care. Do not provoke
instability.



MOULD DIAGRAMS — STAGE 1



Not satire

The Clay Man

Over the following weeks, Kamile taught him Greek. Primo learned steadily, without drama, absorbing what he was given and quietly asking for more. He had a gift for names. He wanted to know what everything was called: tools, hills, birds that came to the high window. He pointed and waited. Hawk, Kamile would say. Primo would repeat it, nodding as though filing it away. He was a good man.

Kamile had felt it in the making—how evenly the soul had settled, without resistance, like oil finding its level. Some souls fought even as they entered, though "fought" was not quite right—hesitated. Primo accepted what he was given and became completely himself. It was Primo who chose the sea. Kamile never directed his creations toward particular lives. He gave them language, a sense of the world and practical knowledge enough to find their footing. Then he let them pursue whatever drew them.

He had learned that the pull came from the soul—his soul, divided and specific to each man, each fragment carrying a piece of his own inclination. Kamile had always loved water, so it did not surprise him when, on his fourteenth day, Primo walked down to the coast, stood at its edge for a long time and returned with his hands at his sides and his face doing something no language named. "I want to fish," he said. "Then fish," Kamile replied.

Kamile found him a place among the fishermen of a small harbour three hours' walk away: a cove with a dozen boats and a community organised around the sea, as such places always are—practical, superstitious and suspicious of anyone from inland. Primo was from inland. It took him two weeks to be accepted. He succeeded as one must: by being useful before being liked. He learned the nets and the tides.

He learned which older fishermen wanted conversation before dawn and which wanted silence, and he supplied whichever was needed without appearing to notice. He had that almost-smile, and strangers felt known by it. Within a month, every man in the harbour felt Primo had been there longer than he had. He was happy. Kamile visited twice that first season, watching from the hillside and taking care with his feelings. The joy planted in him remained, but he knew how easily it could resemble pride.

Pride was not the point. The work was simple and painful: make a man who is happy. That was all it had ever been. At first, neither of them noticed the damage. Primo saw it before Kamile did but said nothing because he did not know what he saw. He only noticed that the skin of his forearms, after a day at sea, looked different—smoother, less defined, like a riverbank after a season of water. By the second year, it was clear to anyone who looked, though the fishermen didn't.

They saw each other as colleagues, competitors or friends—not through eyes attuned to deterioration. But Kamile noticed the third time he visited. Sitting with Primo on the harbour wall in afternoon light, he looked at his hands and felt something drop through him. The fingers worked, but the edges had softened. The knuckles he had shaped with care were rounding off, the way stone smooths under a fountain. "Does it hurt?" Kamile asked. Primo considered seriously. "No. Should it?" "I don't know," Kamile said, truthfully.

They sat awhile. "I know what I am," Primo said—not as accusation but as statement. He had always learned by observation and patience. "You made me." "Yes." "I'm made of earth, and the sea is taking me back." Kamile said nothing. "That seems," Primo said, pausing to watch the late light turn the water gold, the boats knocking gently together, "like something the gods would arrange." "Yes," Kamile said. "It does."

Primo nodded, interested rather than distressed. He had always wanted to know what things were called. He filed this away and looked at the sea. He fished for another year. By then his face had lost its fine detail—the angle of the nose, the slight asymmetry of the ears. He was becoming simpler: a shape that suggested "man" without insisting on it. Yet he still knew the nets, the tides and which fishermen needed silence before dawn. He still provided it.

One morning he went out alone to deeper water where the serious fish were. The others watched him go without concern. There was nothing yet to fear. When he hadn't returned by noon, they searched and found his boat drifting. The nets were neatly stowed; the oars were shipped. There were no signs of struggle or anything out of place—just the boat and the water, untroubled, going down into darkness, taking back what it had been given. Kamile heard two days later.

He walked to the cove, stood where he had sat with Primo and thought about fingers and softened edges. He thought: waterproof. He returned to the workshop, set his hands in the clay and began again.



IDENTITY TAG

SUBJECT: CLAY MAN
STATUS: LEARNING
ORIGIN: KAMILE'S WORKSHOP
LOCATION: COAST / SMALL HARBOUR
CLASSIFICATION: MAN - EARTH
OBSERVATION: SEA-DRAWN
DATE: DAY 14*



MAGISTRATE DORION
CIVIC AUTHORITY

Language instructs.
Choice reveals.
The sea collects.

PHILOSOPHER LYKEON
NATURAL INQUIRIES

Water returns what
it receives. Watch
for softening.

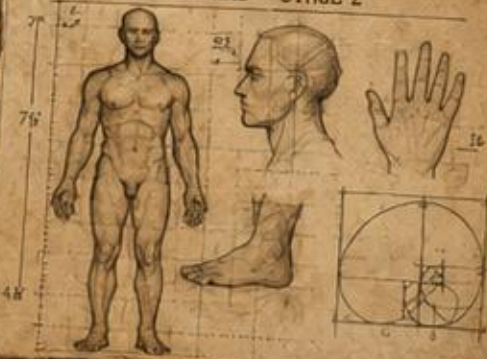


LAB SUPERVISOR NERAUD
RESEARCH COUNCIL

Deterioration noted.
Noted also:
happiness.
Both are data.



MOULD DIAGRAMS - STAGE 2



FIELD OBSERVER'S SKETCH



WITNESS STATEMENTS - FORM 17B

NAME / ROLE	STATEMENT (SUMMARY)	SIGNATURE
FISHERMAN ARIS (Net Mender)	Useful. Speaks when asked. Knows the tide.	<i>Aris</i>
BOATOWNER MELAS	Paid his share. No trouble. Good with hands.	<i>Melas</i>
FISHERMAN THADOS	Sits quiet. Helps more than he says.	<i>Thados</i>
ELDER WOMAN DORA (Harbour)	Kind eyes. Eats what is given. Blessed the nets.	<i>Dora</i>

FILED: MONTH 2

FOR OFFICIAL USE ONLY

Not satire

Chapter Two — Yiorgos

Kamile approached his next creation differently. He thought about Primo not with grief alone but with the attention of a craftsman reviewing his work for error. Sitting at the long table, he turned the problem over in his mind as he turned the clay.

The answer was simple, and he disliked it for its simplicity. He had made Primo of earth and sent him to live on water without considering what water does to earth over time. He had not thought like a potter. He had thought like a father, which was the mistake. Fathers do not think about material. They think about the child. He would not repeat that.

For Yiorgos he spent three days choosing clay, climbing further up the hillside than usual to a deposit above the treeline, where centuries of pressure made it dense and serious. He kneaded it longer than necessary, past readiness, until it was tighter and less willing to yield. He mixed in a small amount of fired clay, ground fine: strength inside softness—a skeleton of what had survived fire. He was pleased with the material.

He waterproofed less thoroughly than he would later, applying a fine surface treatment he had devised over winter—a sealing that left the appearance unchanged but closed the pores against water and weather. Primo had been open to everything; Yiorgos would be shielded from the worst. Kamile built him broad and unhurried. Not a soldier's body—this man was not for war. A farmer's body built for long, repetitive work: shoulders to carry, a back that could bend all day and straighten again, hands with grip.

As always, he did the face last. He gave Yiorgos a wide, patient face with creases around the eyes, as though he spent his life looking far ahead, and a mouth that didn't smile easily but meant it when it did. He pressed his thumb into the chest and felt a piece of himself leave. Yiorgos opened his eyes, looked at the ceiling and breathed. He accepted life immediately. He took to the land as Primo had taken to the sea—not by decision but by recognition.

Kamile found him a farm two days' walk east: a modest holding in a valley with a house, a barn, an olive grove, two fields and a horse named by no one in particular—Kephos, a large bay with a calm eye that had been left with a neighbour and seemed pleased to have someone permanent again. Yiorgos surveyed the property in silence. "The olives need attention," he said at last. "Yes," Kamile replied. "I'll start there." He did. He pruned the olives hard and they rewarded him the next season.

He turned the fields, learned their drainage and planted accordingly. He repaired the stone walls with pleasure rather than obligation. He named the horse Kephos because it sounded right and treated him with the quiet patience of someone who understands that animals respond to consistency, not force. Kamile visited in the second season and found him content. Not happy like Primo—whose joy had been immediate and bright—but quietly satisfied, the kind that announces itself only in its absence.

He fed Kamile, showed him the grove and discussed the soil as one still learning it. He had good neighbours and a steady rhythm. "You seem well," Kamile said. "I am well," Yiorgos answered, as if confirming a measurement. Kamile walked home and allowed himself to feel joy fully, alone on the road with hills glowing around him. It was his joy. Entirely his.

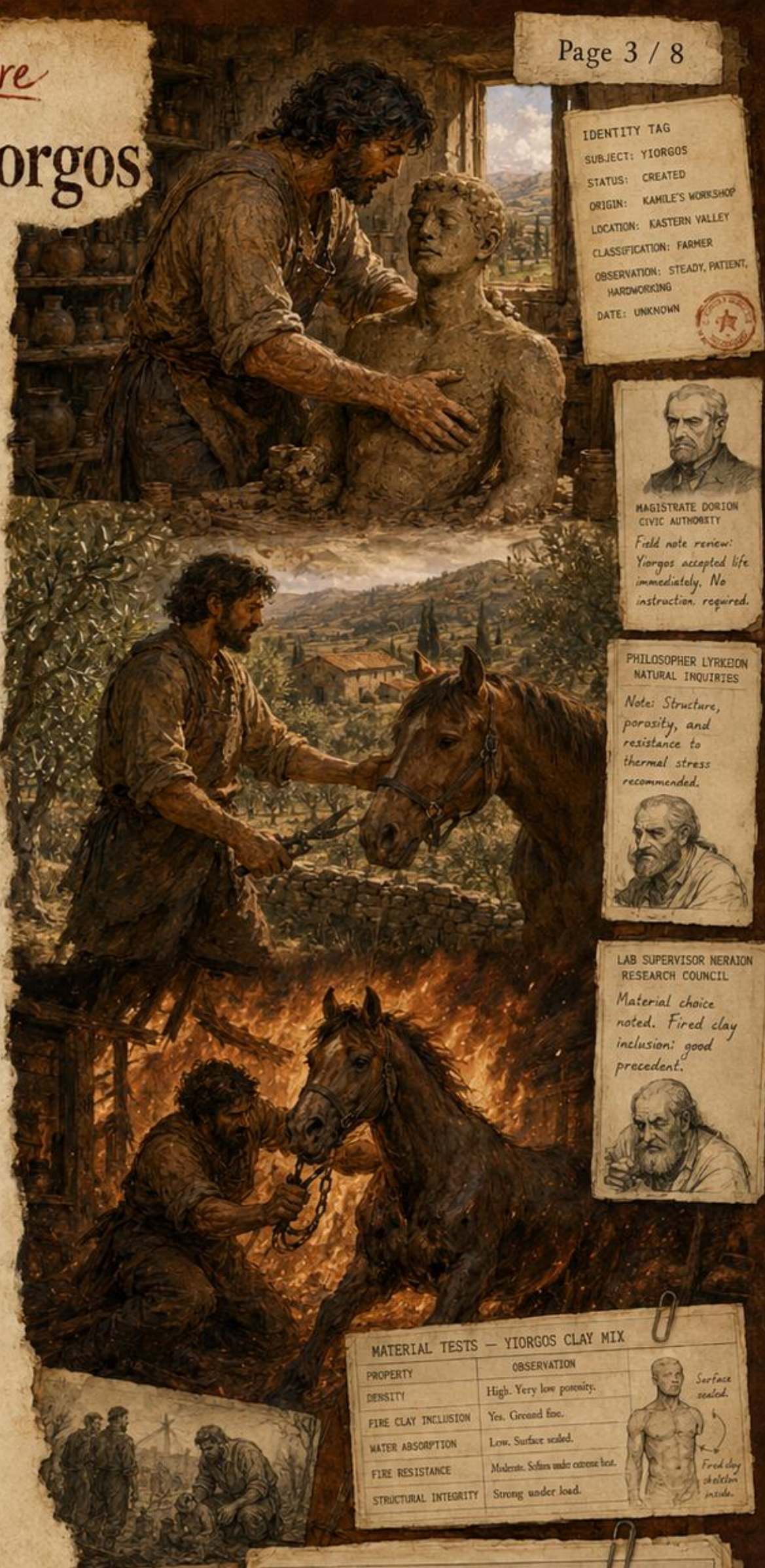
Then came the fire. No one knew the cause. On dry farms, fires happen: a lamp, a spark, built-up heat. Yiorgos woke to smoke and found the stable already burning, orange light enormous in the dark, Kephos's frantic sounds loud and continuous. Neighbours formed a bucket line and attacked the blaze with the urgency of people accustomed to how fast fire moves and how much it takes. Yiorgos looked at the stable, at the bucket line, and made a calculation. He didn't hesitate.

He went in through a side door that had not yet caught, straight into Kephos's stall, moving low and fast, speaking to the horse in his low, constant murmur—I'm here, nothing will hurt you. The smoke was thick and the heat immense, a weight with intent. He reached Kephos. The horse was beyond reassurance—white-eyed, crashing against walls. Yiorgos grabbed his halter and held on. What the fire was doing to him he could not feel; he had no nerves.

His clay, though mixed and sealed, was softening from the moment he entered. The horse weighed more than two men and pulled with everything he had. Yiorgos held on. He held on because he was made from a soul that always held on. The separation was quiet, like cutting wet clay with a wire. His upper half still held the halter for a moment longer than it should have. Then he lay on the stable floor. Kephos burst through the door into the night. The fire consumed everything.

When the neighbours found him later, they did not understand what they saw. They stood in the ruins in the grey morning and tried to explain it to each other in quiet voices. They were confused more than frightened. One older man crouched and rubbed the clay between his fingers thoughtfully. They buried what remained under the olive grove because it felt right. The trees thrived there for many years, and people remarked on it without knowing why it felt significant.

They found Kephos two fields over, unhurt, grazing calmly. Kamile heard and walked east. He stood among the olives and thought about what heat did before the horse did. He thought about structure and what holds under pressure. He thought: strength—real strength, not density; something that doesn't soften. He thought about a soldier—about a man who could bear the weight of the world and not break. He walked back to the workshop and the waiting clay.



IDENTITY TAG

SUBJECT: YIORGOS
STATUS: CREATED
ORIGIN: KAMILE'S WORKSHOP
LOCATION: KASTERN VALLEY
CLASSIFICATION: FARMER
OBSERVATION: STEADY, PATIENT,
HARDWORKING
DATE: UNKNOWN

MAGISTRATE DORION
CIVIC AUTHORITY

Field note review:
Yiorgos accepted life
immediately. No
instruction required.

PHILOSOPHER LYRKEION
NATURAL INQUIRIES

Note: Structure,
porosity, and
resistance to
thermal stress
recommended.

LAB SUPERVISOR NERAION
RESEARCH COUNCIL

Material choice
noted. Fired clay
inclusion: good
precedent.



MATERIAL TESTS — YIORGOS CLAY MIX

PROPERTY	OBSERVATION
DENSITY	High. Very low porosity.
FIRE CLAY INCLUSION	Yes. Ground fine.
WATER ABSORPTION	Low. Surface sealed.
FIRE RESISTANCE	Moderate. Softens under extreme heat.
STRUCTURAL INTEGRITY	Strong under load.



FIELD OBSERVER'S SKETCH

WITNESS NOTE
(HEARD OUTSIDE)

"No cracks without
water or complaint.
The olives speak
for him."

Recorded by
Neighbour, 2nd Season.

FINGERPRINTS: YIORGOS

Pottery:
Diplo-Loop
Broad
Deep

FILED: DAY 14

FOR OFFICIAL USE ONLY

Chapter Three — Atlas

Kamile built Atlas like an argument. Every decision answered Yiorgos's death: the stable floor, the clean separation, the old man rubbing clay between his fingers. Kamile had lain awake with that image too many nights. He dug deeper into the upland deposit, below the layer he had used for Yiorgos, to where clay was almost stone. It came out dark and resistant. He worked it for days; his hands and wrists ached. Good, he thought. If it fights me, it will fight everything.

He fired sections in his kiln, then ground the fired clay and mixed it back into the raw material. He repeated this three times. The result was unlike any clay he had used—a material that pushed back instead of yielding. He built Atlas large, at the edge of what men are—not grotesque, but a man who made doorframes seem like suggestions. The chest was deep, the shoulders broad, the neck thick enough to support a head capable of decisions under weight.

He built the back carefully, layer by layer, like a wall that must last, always placing something behind wherever the force would pass through. He built strong legs meant to carry the weight of a man in full bronze marching on bad terrain for as long as necessary. Running never occurred to him; he was thinking about standing and holding. He gave Atlas a broad, serious face—heavy brows, a jaw suggesting conclusions rather than questions, eyes set wide and level. He pressed his thumb to the chest.

The piece of himself that left was larger than usual. He had become practised at this loss, but practice brings no immunity. Each time was new. Atlas opened his eyes, looked at the ceiling and breathed. The breathing was slower, deeper—bellows rather than lungs. He sat up easily and looked at his hands, then at Kamile with a face already waiting for information. "You'll want to stand," Kamile said. Atlas stood. He filled the room differently than the others—not aggressively but inevitably.

The room reorganised itself around him. The ceiling seemed lower, the walls nearer. He existed in a way that rearranged space. "Good," Kamile said, and meant it. He did not send Atlas to war, nor did Atlas seek violence. Instead, he became a guardian—a protector of smaller things. He settled in a mountain community three days north, a place of goatherds and farmers living on a pass connecting two valleys. Weather came fast, terrain was unforgiving, and people often needed strength more than strategy.

Atlas helped with everything. He steadied collapsing roofs, freed trapped animals and moved heavy objects. Emergencies that arrived suddenly and required someone to stand in a bad place and hold on found him ready. He was good at this as naturally as Primo had been with the sea and Yiorgos with the land. The settlement accepted him as mountain people accept useful things: without excessive sentiment but with deep reliability. He belonged to them. They sent for him when matters were serious.

He rarely talked. Language had been given to him, but he used it sparingly, understanding that most situations require action before words. When he spoke, people listened because his words always had weight.

Kamile visited his guardian in the first winter. They sat by the fire in the communal hall and said little. The joy moved through Kamile. "Are you content?" he asked. Atlas considered. "I am where I should be." Kamile thought that might be the best answer he had ever received.

Not satire

IDENTITY TAG

SUBJECT: ATLAS
STATUS: GUARDIAN
ORIGIN: KAMILE'S WORKSHOP
LOCATION: NORTH PASS COMMUNITY
CLASSIFICATION: PROTECTOR
OBSERVATION: ACTIVE
DATE: DAY 63, WINTER 1

STRUCTURAL NOTES

- Internal lattice reinforced
- Layered load distribution
- Force channels routed through back and legs
- Core density: High
- Stability rating: Maximum



COMMUNITY ROLE

Protector
Builder
Rescuer
Helper
Guardian

PHILOSOPHER LYKEION NATURAL INQUIRIES

Atlas shows that strength need not seek war. Useful strength is the highest form.



LAB SUPERVISOR NERAJON RESEARCH COUNCIL

Structural integrity exceptional.
Endurance beyond expectation.



ATLAS: STRUCTURAL DIAGRAMS — STAGE 3



FIELD OBSERVER'S SKETCH



WITNESS STATEMENTS — FORM 17B

NAME / ROLE	STATEMENT (SUMMARY)	SIGNATURE
ELENI (Goatherd)	Reliable in storms.	Eleni
PETROS (Farmer)	Steadied our roof. Saved our animals.	Petros
DAKOS (Miller)	Moves what many men cannot.	Dakos
MARA (Healer)	Quiet. Kind. Present. Always there.	Mara

FILED: DAY 63

FOR OFFICIAL USE ONLY

FINGERPRINTS: ATLAS



Right
Thumb

Recorded for
structural
verification

WITNESS NOTE (ELENI OF NORTH PASS)

He lifted a boulder the size of our barn roof with one hand. Then he set it down like bread.

Recorded
Day 71

Not satire

The Clay Man

He was with Atlas on the mountain when the pass gave way. He had come for a second visit, following the high path with his satchel over one shoulder—tools, oilcloth, and a quantity of dark clay he now carried habitually. The sky had looked wrong since morning—a grey mountains produce when they are about to act. Kamile noted it but continued; he had visited his creations long enough to develop the stubbornness of old men about weather.

They were on a narrow traverse where the path ran along the cliff face, the valley far below. The mountain moved—not all at once. First a deep, structural sound that arrived in the chest before the ears. Then a crack above, sharp and definite. Then small rocks, scattering. Then the rest. Kamile looked up and felt cold move through him. He looked at Atlas. Atlas was already examining the bottleneck ahead, where the path narrowed to a single man's width—the throat where the rockslide would funnel.

He looked at Kamile's satchel, the tools and clay pressing against the fabric. His eyes, made to measure distance accurately, assessed and concluded. Kamile opened his mouth. "Atlas—" Atlas placed his hand on Kamile's chest and pushed him toward the narrow section—not roughly, simply, with finality, like closing a door. "Go," he said. "Atlas—" "Go." He turned around. He walked to where the path widened slightly, where a man his size could stand across it and become a wall. He planted his feet.

The rocks came down. He held. Kamile ran. He ran through the bottleneck with rocks hammering above, dust filling the air, the sound immense. He did not look back because he couldn't. If he looked, he would stop, and if he stopped, Atlas's choice would be wasted. He emerged on the other side and ran until he could run no further.

Dust settled. The narrow section was gone, replaced by a raw heap of stone sealing the pass. Atlas was nowhere. Only the mountain remained, rearranged. Kamile knelt on the path.

The valley below was distant; someone called out, their voice small. He thought about the hand on his chest, the satchel, the calculation in Atlas's eyes. Atlas died so the next one could live, he thought. He knew that. He saw what *I* carried and understood. He placed his hand on the satchel and felt the tools and clay. Then he stood and walked toward the valley, thinking about legs—about speed and lightness and the capacity to cover ground quickly. He thought: run. Behind him, the mountain was quiet and entirely finished with the matter.

Chapter Four Androcles

Androcles returned from war the way men do who have seen too much of what they went for. He was not broken or hollowed, but he was changed—quietly and permanently. He walked back into the valley one autumn morning with his pack on his back, his sword at his hip and the look of someone finished with something and unsure what came next.

He had heard of Kamile as unusual stories are told—indirectly, through the silence that surrounds them: the sculptor on the hill, the men he makes, how they live and die, and how he keeps making them. Most people who heard felt fear and unease and wanted to talk about something else. Androcles felt something different. Three days after his return, he climbed the hill and knocked on the workshop door.

In the early light he said, "I want to learn how to make something live." Kamile studied him: the soldier's bearing, the soldier's eyes and something underneath moving away from what he'd been.

"Why?"

"Because I've spent four years learning how to end things," Androcles said. "And I'm done with that."

Kamile stood back.

"Come in, then."

FINGERPRINTS: KAMILE
Right Thumb

Recovered from Workshop Bench

FIELD OBSERVER'S SKETCH



WITNESS NOTE
(HEARD OUTSIDE)

Rocks falling
Huge sound
Man held

Recorded by
M. Theros

IDENTITY TAG

SUBJECT: CLAY MAN
STATUS: UNNAMED
ORIGIN: KAMILE'S WORKSHOP
LOCATION: RED-SPUR VALLEY
CLASSIFICATION: UNDETERMINED
OBSERVATION: ACTIVE
DATE: DAWN, DAY ?



MAGISTRATE DORION
CIVIC AUTHORITY

Another decisive
act. Life preserved
by sacrifice.
Note the calculation.

PHILOSOPHER LYKEON
NATURAL INQUIRIES

Heroism, perhaps.
Or instinct shaped
by purpose.
Fine line.



LAB SUPERVISOR NERAUN
RESEARCH COUNCIL

Sacrificial behavior
observed in animals.
Rarity in humans—
worthy of record.

MOUNTAIN PASS — SECTION VIEW



WITNESS STATEMENTS — FORM 17B

NAME / ROLE	STATEMENT (SUMMARY)	SIGNATURE
MAGISTRATE DORION (Civic Authority)	The sculptor's actions deliberate and self-sacrificing.	Dorion
PHILOSOPHER LYKEON (Natural Inquiries)	Choice under pressure. Ethical framework notable.	Lykeon
LAB SUPERVISOR NERAUN (Research Council)	Sacrifice enhances survival probability of subject.	Neraun

FILED: DAY ?

FOR OFFICIAL USE ONLY

Not satire

The Clay Man

He had seriousness the young seldom manage and the patience of someone who knows impatience kills. His hands were skilled and needed only to be retrained. At first, he was not gentle. His hands knew force and applied it. The clay resisted, and he applied more.

Kamile watched for three days before speaking.

"You're trying to win," Kamile said. Androcles looked up.

"The clay isn't an opponent," Kamile said. "You're not trying to defeat it.

You're trying to discover what it wants to be."

"That's not how I was taught," Androcles said.

"No," Kamile said. "I imagine not."

It took almost a year to unlearn force, but he did. By winter's end, he could work clay for hours with the attentive quality Kamile recognised and valued. They worked side by side most mornings, sometimes talking, sometimes not. Their silence was the good kind—two people doing the same thing and both knowing it. In the afternoons Kamile taught him theory.

Not the soul—no one can teach that—but everything around it: selecting clay, preparation, workable proportions, surface treatments and firing techniques. It was the hard knowledge Kamile had paid for with four lives. For the first time, he passed it on.

"Why do you keep going?" Androcles asked one evening in the second year. They were outside, the valley darkening and the first stars appearing. It was the kind of question for that kind of evening. Kamile thought.

"Because I love it." "Because when they breathe—for the first time—I feel something I can't feel any other way."

"Even knowing what happens after?"

"Yes."

Androcles was quiet. "That's either very wise or very foolish."

"I've never been sure which," Kamile said.

Androcles almost smiled—Kamile recognised the expression from Primo and realised he had given away a part of himself without knowing. "I think doing what you love, knowing the cost, is the only honest way to live," Androcles said.

Kamile looked at the stars and said nothing, feeling joy move through him like weather.

By the third year Androcles could build a man. He could not bring him to life—only Kamile could give the soul—but he could shape one from raw material with a confidence no longer that of a student. His hands had completed their retraining.

One day, he presented a clay man. Kamile walked around it, looking from every angle. "Well?" Androcles asked.

"The left shoulder," Kamile said.

Androcles nodded, adjusted.

"Better," Kamile said.

"The face?"

"The face is good," Kamile answered after studying it. "Very good."

Androcles had given the man a mouth that rested in an almost-smile. Kamile noticed and did not mention it.

In the fourth year, Androcles began asking about the soul.

Carefully, with the patience he had learned from clay, he asked what it felt like, what left and what remained, whether the piece that went into the clay returned when a clay man died.

"It doesn't return," Kamile said. "I keep giving it."

"How much do you have left?"

"Enough for one," Kamile said. "Perhaps."

Androcles took this in as he had taken in difficult information in the field—steadily. "Then we have to make sure the next one is right," he said.

"Yes," Kamile said. "Tell me everything you haven't told me."

So Kamile told him. Primo and the sea; Yiorgos, the fire and the horse; Atlas, the mountain and the hand on his chest; the satchel, the tools and the calculation.

Androcles listened with his hands still and his eyes level. When Kamile finished, he was quiet.

"Atlas died so you could be here," Androcles said.

"Yes."

"So you could make the next one."

"Yes."

"And I'm meant to carry it on," Androcles said—not a question, just naming the fact.

"That was what I hoped," Kamile said.

Androcles nodded slowly, looking at his hands—the hands that had unlearned force, the hands that could build a man with a good face. "Then I'd better learn the rest," he said.

FINGERPRINTS: ANDROCLES

Right
Thumb



Recorded for
apprentice record.

WITNESS NOTE
(EXTRACT)

Hands once hard
as stone now move
with care.
Patient.
Observant.
Ready.

Recorded by
L. Thespis

FIELD OBSERVER'S SKETCH



IDENTITY TAG

SUBJECT: ANDROCLES
STATUS: APPRENTICE
ORIGIN: UNKNOWN
LOCATION: KAMILE'S WORKSHOP
CLASSIFICATION: APPRENTICE
OBSERVATION: RETRAINING HANDS
DATE: YEAR 2



KAMILE
MASTER & TEACHER

Note to apprentice:
Clay is not conquered.
It is listened to.

PHILOSOPHER: ANDROCLES
APPRENTICE NOTES

To shape is to listen.
To listen is to wait.
To wait is the hardest
part of work.



LAB SUPERVISOR: KERAINOS
RESEARCH COUNCIL

Apprenticeship approved.
Progress: satisfactory.
Observe for readiness
by Year 4.



CLAY PROCESS - STAGE 2

1. SELECT
CLAY



2. PREPARE
& SLURRY



3. WEDGE
& MIX



4. SHAPE
WITH CARE



5. DRY
SLOWLY



6. SURFACE
TREATMENT



7. FIRE
WITH PATIENCE



WITNESS STATEMENTS - FORM 17B

NAME / ROLE	STATEMENT (SUMMARY)	SIGNATURE
MAGISTRATE DORION (Civic Authority)	Observed consistent instruction and application of approved methods.	<i>[Signature]</i>
PHILOSOPHER LYRICON (Natural Inquiries)	Questions now of substance, not rebellion. Progress affirmed.	<i>[Signature]</i>
LAB SUPERVISOR KERAINOS (Research Council)	Apprentice demonstrates readiness for advanced knowledge.	<i>[Signature]</i>

FILED: YEAR 4

FOR OFFICIAL USE ONLY

The Clay Man

Not satire

It was an ordinary late-summer afternoon: hot, bright, the smell of dry grass and insects in the valley. Androcles went to the upland deposit for clay—a familiar path he could have walked blindfolded. He carried two empty buckets, moving easily. Kamile was in the workshop working on a new surface treatment. He was absorbed when it happened. The gods were fighting far above—actually fighting, not through signs or weather. Bolts of divine violence shed off like sparks from a hammer.

One stray bolt fell through the clear sky and struck the path where Androcles walked with his buckets and hands that knew how to find what clay wanted to be. Kamile felt it through the workshop floor before he heard it. He was outside before the sound ended. The path above was scorched along a single, decisive line. Two buckets lay as they had been—one upright, one on its side. The air smelled of something completely reduced from one thing to nothing. There was no Androcles, no trace.

The afternoon continued indifferent: insects hummed, light persisted. Kamile stood on the path a long time. He did not look at the sky. The gods were gone, their argument continuing elsewhere, already done with this valley. They had not noticed. They had not even noticed. He crouched and touched the scorched earth. Still warm. He thought of four years of mornings, of hands learning to loosen, of an almost-smile on a face Androcles had made without knowing its origin. Enough for one, he had said. Perhaps.

He stayed until the earth cooled and the evening came. Then he picked up the buckets—leaving them felt wrong—and carried them back to the workshop. He sat at the long table with the last of his clay and his tools. He thought about Atlas's hand and Androcles's words. He thought about a name he had not yet used: Loretto, victory.

— Chapter Five — Loretto —

The workshop was dark except for a single lamp. Kamile hadn't lit it intentionally; his hand had moved on its own, the body keeping busy while the mind went where the body could not follow. The lamp cast a small circle of yellow light over the clay and the tools wrapped in oilcloth. The final piece of his soul sat in his chest like a stone and a seed. He had been sitting a long time. Outside, the valley was dark, stars scattered overhead and a night bird called, indifferent yet somehow comforting. The world was ready to continue without him.

The clay waited, patient and opinionless. He thought about the gods. He thought about confronting them in a high place above the weather. He imagined waiting until they noticed him, reminding them they had made him for this, that they had given him not just compulsion but joy—the love that would keep him going and fund their experiment with his happiness. He imagined accusing them of making his love serve their purpose.

He imagined them explaining that love was his alone, that purpose inevitably follows what is genuine. He imagined asking about Primo, Yiorgos and Atlas; he imagined their reverence for Atlas's choice. He imagined asking about Androcles. There would be silence—Androcles was not design or purpose, merely a stray bolt from a divine argument. Their silence would be honest. He imagined asking why they allow such bolts. "We don't govern every detail," they would say. He imagined asking what they were for.

"The same thing you are for," they would answer. "We make things." But these were only thoughts—journeys that return with no answers, only a clearer shape of the question. He was still at the table with clay and the last piece of himself. The decision would not arrive as certainty but as choice. Choices are harder and more meaningful. He thought about Primo: the broad nose, the almost-smile, the way he accepted his nature and looked at the sea.

FINGERPRINTS: KAMILE

Right Thumb

Recovered from oilcloth wrap (Tool Roll)

WITNESS NOTE
(HEARD OUTSIDE)
Loud report.
Instant light.
Silence.
No further sound.

Recorded by
M. Theas



FIELD OBSERVER'S SKETCH



WITNESS STATEMENTS – FORM 17B

NAME / ROLE	STATEMENT (SUMMARY)	SIGNATURE
MAGISTRATE DORION (Civic Authority)	No survivors found. Scene consistent with divine strike.	<i>[Signature]</i>
PHILOSOPHER LYKEON (Natural Inquiries)	Thermal & spiritual anomaly. Extraterrestrial agency.	<i>[Signature]</i>
LAB SUPERVISOR NERAUD (Research Council)	Arc discharge from unknown source. Outlier event.	<i>[Signature]</i>

FILED: DAY 1

FOR OFFICIAL USE ONLY

IDENTITY TAG

SUBJECT: CLAY MAN
STATUS: UNKNOWN
ORIGIN: KAMILE'S WORKSHOP
LOCATION: UPLAND DEPOSIT
CLASSIFICATION: TARGETED LOSS
OBSERVATION: DIVINE STRIKE
DATE: LATE-SUMMER DAY



MAGISTRATE DORION
CIVIC AUTHORITY

A tragedy with no
witnessed survivors.
Irrelevant to law—
but recorded.

PHILOSOPHER LYKEON
NATURAL INQUIRIES

Divine conflict
produces entropy.
Collateral is
inevitable.



LAB SUPERVISOR NERAUD
RESEARCH COUNCIL

Standard deviation
beyond parameters.
Note for celestial
mechanics.



UPLAND SITE MAP – SECTION B



Not satire

The Clay Man

He thought about Yiorgos: his silence in the olive grove, the soil he was still learning, the grove that thrived where he lay. He thought about the place in himself around Atlas that still ached and could not be approached directly. He thought about Androcles: wanting to create life after ending lives, unlearning force, saying that to do what you love while knowing the cost is the only honest way to live. He thought about that almost-smile resurfacing unexpectedly.

He thought about Atlas's hand on his chest. He thought about Androcles's promise to learn the rest, cut short by a bolt the gods did not even aim. He thought about what it would mean to keep the last piece of his soul for himself—to live mornings and evenings without the cost of making. He tried to imagine life without making and found it an unknown landscape his mind couldn't map. Perhaps that inability came from the love the gods had planted, disguising itself as his own imagination's limit. Perhaps not.

He didn't know. He placed his hand on the clay. The cool, dense upland clay he had prepared over weeks without deciding—a reflex—waited with its usual patience. He thought of Loretto, the name he had never used. Victory. But victory for whom? If he made Loretto and Loretto lived and carried the craft onward, would that be his triumph or the gods'? Was there a difference? The gods might say the love came from him and was always his, but his work had served their purpose. Did that matter? He didn't know.

He thought about Atlas. Someone died so he could sit at this table. Atlas turned so he could be here with clay and tools and the last of himself. That fact required no answer; it simply sat with him. He thought about all the men he had not made yet. He thought about the joy he felt when the chest rose and fell for the first time. That joy was his, entirely his, whatever the gods intended. He sat with the weight of his choice. Outside, the night bird fell silent. Dawn lightened the edge of the hills.

The earth waited, patient, ready, without opinion. The gods were elsewhere, already arguing about something new. The lamp flickered. Kamile sat. Only he could decide. It had always been his choice.

Written in the time of the gods, when the earth was still learning what it could become.

FINGERPRINTS: KAMILE

WITNESS NOTE
(DAWN OBSERVATION)

Sound of night bird ceased. Dawn lightened. Lamp flickered. Kamile sat.

Recorded by
M. Theras

FIELD OBSERVER'S SKETCH



WITNESS STATEMENTS - FORM 17B

NAME / ROLE	STATEMENT (SUMMARY)	SIGNATURE
MAGISTRATE DORION (Civic Authority)	Observe craft at a distance. If life signs exhibited require without external aid.	<i>[Signature]</i>
PHILOSOPHER LYKEON (Natural Inquiries)	Subject demonstrates emergent properties warranting inquiry.	<i>[Signature]</i>
LAB SUPERVISOR NERAION (Research Council)	Recommend continued monitoring and ethical review.	<i>[Signature]</i>

FILED: DAWN, DAY 2

FOR OFFICIAL USE ONLY

IDENTITY TAG

SUBJECT: CLAY MAN
STATUS: UNNAMED
ORIGIN: KAMILE'S WORKSHOP
LOCATION: KER-SOLO VALLEY
CLASSIFICATION: INDETERMINED
OBSERVATION: ACTIVE
DATE: DAWN, DAY 2



MAGISTRATE DORION
CIVIC AUTHORITY

*Requires review.
If it breathes, it may
be subject to law.*

PHILOSOPHER LYKEON
NATURAL INQUIRIES

*What is it when
something is made
and yet begins
on its own?*



LAB SUPERVISOR NERAION
RESEARCH COUNCIL

*Recommend observation
protocols: Handle with
care. Do not provoke
instability.*



MOULD DIAGRAMS - FINAL FORM

